

Amid Nature

From leopard country in Jawai and lion territory in Gir to the rhino habitats of Assam—luxury hotel chains are expanding their wildlife portfolios

BY **SMITA TRIPATHI**

IMAGINE WAKING UP to the sounds of the wilderness, tracking leopards across Jawai's granite hills in Rajasthan, meeting the Rabari community and ending the day with a private dinner under the stars. Or heading into Gir's forests, Assam's rhino country or Ladakh's snow-leopard terrain, with expert naturalists and luxury comforts. For India's affluent travellers, a holiday in the wild is increasingly about much more than the thrill of spotting a tiger. It is about slowing down, discovering new landscapes, connecting with local communities, and experiencing nature, without compromising on luxury.

For the hospitality industry, this changing appetite is a significant business opportunity. Large hotel chains, including IHCL, ITC Hotels, Marriott International, and The Oberoi Group, are expanding their wildlife portfolios, while specialist operators are developing intimate, experience-led lodges. More important, expansion is no longer restricted to established tiger destinations such as Ranthambore, Kanha, and Bandhavgarh.

The opportunity is substantial. According to Akash Datta, Managing Director (South Asia), HVS Anarock, India's branded wildlife hospitality segment had approximately 3,300 operational rooms as of June 2026, with another 3,700 planned through 2030, doubling the branded inventory over the next four years.

"Historically dominated by independent operators, often catering largely to international travellers, the strong growth in domestic leisure demand is now bringing greater institutional participation," says Datta.

BUILDING A WILDLIFE CIRCUIT

For Kapil Chopra, Founder and CEO of luxury hotel chain The Postcard Hotel, the aim is not to open another luxury hotel near a national park, but to create an entire circuit of luxury wildlife experiences.

"Africa has done a phenomenal job. India, on the other hand, has extraordinary wildlife but, barring a few destinations such as Ranthambore, has historically struggled to create enough luxury hotels of global standards across its wildlife circuit," says Chopra. He believes this represents one of the biggest opportunities in Indian hospitality today.

The Postcard Hotel is building a portfolio covering multiple wildlife habitats. Its existing properties include The Postcard Gir Wildlife Sanctuary, The Postcard in the Himalayan Willows in Leh, from where it plans to introduce winter snow-leopard safaris, and The Postcard in the Durrung Tea Estate, a 1,400-acre estate